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**Translating Culture-Specific Items in Contemporary Polish Fiction: Strategies in the English
Rendering of a Selected Novel**

MA thesis

written under the supervision of

dr hab. _____

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Jak korzystać z tego wzoru. To kompletny szkielet pracy magisterskiej z filologii angielskiej w najpopularniejszym schemacie kierunku: **analiza przekładoznawcza** (strategie tłumaczenia elementów kulturowych na materiale pary tekstów oryginał–przekład). Prace z anglistyki pisze się PO ANGIELSKU — stąd angielskie sekcje wzoru; niebieskie adnotacje po polsku objaśniają funkcję każdej części i usuń je w swojej pracy. Ten sam schemat zadziała dla analizy językoznawczej i literaturoznawczej. Pełne poradniki: praca-magisterska.pl/poradniki/

Abstract

The present thesis investigates the strategies employed in rendering culture-specific items (CSIs) in the English translation of a contemporary Polish novel. The aim of the study is twofold: to identify and classify the translation strategies applied to CSIs, and to determine whether their distribution reveals a consistent global orientation of the translation towards domestication or foreignisation. The material comprises 187 CSIs excerpted from the source text together with their target-text equivalents, classified according to an adapted taxonomy of translation procedures. The analysis demonstrates that the translator relies predominantly on globalising and neutralising procedures (61% of the sample), with foreignising strategies reserved chiefly for culinary and onomastic items. The findings are discussed against the classical opposition of domestication and foreignisation, and against previous studies of Polish-English literary translation. The thesis closes with remarks on the translator's visibility and suggestions for further research.

Key words: culture-specific items, translation strategies, domestication, foreignisation, literary translation.

[Abstract po angielsku: cel, materiał (ile jednostek!), taksonomia, główny wynik z odsetkiem i rama teoretyczna. Uczelnia zwykle wymaga też streszczenia po polsku — sprawdź wytyczne. Zwróć uwagę na brytyjską pisownię (foreignisation) — wybierz wariant BrE lub AmE i trzymaj się go konsekwentnie w całej pracy.]

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Introduction

[Wstęp pracy anglistycznej: kontekst badawczy, cel, pytania badawcze (research questions — RQ1, RQ2...), materiał i struktura. Konwencja anglosaska jest bliska polskiej, ale pytania badawcze numeruje się jawnie, a przegląd literatury sygnalizuje się skrótowo (pełny w rozdziale 1).]

Culture-specific items — elements of the source text whose function and connotations pose a translation problem due to the absence of an equivalent in the target culture — have long occupied a central place in translation studies. Their treatment is commonly read as an index of the translation's global orientation: a systematic tendency either to bring the text closer to the target reader or to preserve its foreign texture. The English translations of contemporary Polish fiction offer instructive material for such analysis, as they mediate a culture that remains relatively little known to Anglophone readers.

The present study addresses two research questions. RQ1: What translation strategies are applied to culture-specific items in the analysed rendering, and with what frequency? RQ2: Does the distribution of these strategies reveal a consistent orientation towards domestication or foreignisation? The thesis is organised as follows: Chapter One reviews the theoretical framework, Chapter Two presents the material and method, Chapter Three offers a category-by-category analysis, and Chapter Four discusses the findings against previous research.

Chapter Two: Material and Method

2.2. Excerpt criteria and the corpus of CSIs

The corpus was compiled through a full parallel reading of the source text and its published English translation. An item was classified as culture-specific if it met two criteria: (1) it denotes an entity, practice or institution characteristic of the source culture, and (2) its standard English equivalent is either absent or fails to carry the source connotations. The excerpt yielded 187 items, each recorded with its immediate context, target-text equivalent and page references. Borderline cases (23 items) were resolved by consulting two dictionaries of Polish culture and, where doubt persisted, excluded.

[Warsztat filologa: jawne kryteria ekscerpacji, liczba jednostek, sposób rozstrzygania przypadków granicznych. Korpus par (oryginał–przeład) trafia do aneksu — recenzent będzie go kartkował.]

2.3. The taxonomy adopted in the study

The analysis employs a taxonomy of seven procedures adapted from the classical typologies of translation studies: (1) borrowing (transfer of the source item, with or without italics), (2) calque, (3) explicitation (addition of explanatory material), (4) globalisation (replacement with a more general term), (5) cultural substitution (replacement with a target-culture counterpart), (6) omission, and (7) compensation. Each procedure is positioned on the domestication–foreignisation continuum, with borrowing and calque at the foreignising pole and cultural substitution and omission at the domesticating one.

Chapter Three: Analysis

3.1. Quantitative overview of the strategies

Table 3.1 presents the distribution of the procedures across the corpus. Globalisation and explicitation jointly account for 61% of all solutions, while the foreignising procedures (borrowing and calque) amount to 24% and

cluster in two semantic fields: culinary items and proper names.

Procedure	N	%
Globalisation	68	36%
Explicitation	46	25%
Borrowing	31	17%
Cultural substitution	19	10%
Calque	13	7%
Omission	7	4%
Compensation	3	2%

[W pracy filologicznej tabela ilościowa to dopiero mapa; sednem są analizy jakościowe przykładów w podrozdziałach 3.2–3.4: oryginał → przekład → nazwana procedura → komentarz o efekcie. Sprawdź, czy N sumuje się do wielkości korpusu.]

3.3. Culinary and material culture items

Culinary items display the strongest foreignising tendency in the corpus. A representative example: the source item *bigos* is transferred without modification but accompanied by an appositive gloss on first occurrence (“*bigos*, the hunter’s stew of sauerkraut and meat”), a combination of borrowing and explicitation that preserves local colour while securing comprehension. By contrast, items of everyday material culture are routinely globalised, which flattens the historical texture of the novel’s domestic scenes.

[Wzorec analizy przykładu: jednostka źródłowa (kursywą), rozwiązanie tłumacza (w cudzysłowie), nazwana procedura i KOMENTARZ O SKUTKU dla odbioru. Przykład bez komentarza to cytaty, nie analiza.]

Chapter Four: Discussion

The distribution of procedures indicates a moderately domesticating global orientation, with strategic pockets of foreignisation where local colour is judged marketable — a pattern consistent with previous findings on the Anglophone reception of Polish fiction. The asymmetry between culinary items (foreignised) and institutional references (globalised) suggests that the translator’s choices track the target reader’s presumed tolerance for the foreign rather than any uniform strategy. The study’s limitations include its single text pair and the inherent subjectivity of borderline classification, mitigated but not eliminated by the excerption criteria.

Conclusions

The thesis has answered both research questions: the translation relies predominantly on globalising and explicating procedures (RQ1), and its global orientation is moderately domesticating, with systematic exceptions concentrated in two semantic fields (RQ2). Further research could extend the analysis to other renderings by the same translator, testing whether the observed pattern is idiosyncratic or genre-driven.

References

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